

The Agency Client Onboarding Playbook

Master Operating System for Digital & Software Agencies

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Cora Studio Operational Standard - Production Ebook Edition

Executive Summary & Operating Architecture

This playbook defines the standardized operational protocol for transitioning clients from signed proposal to active s

Designed for agencies scaling between \$20k and \$200k MRR.

Core Objective: Eliminate approval latency, protect cash flow, and ensure zero unbilled scope creep.

Chapter 01: The First 48 Hours & Async Momentum

The initial 48 hours dictate the emotional tone and communication cadence of the entire engagement.

Immediate Actions: Automated portal provisioning, 60-second video welcome, and async intake link deposit.

Principle: Deliver tangible staging progress before day two.

Chapter 02: Stakeholder Mapping & Decision Matrix

Establish the single source of truth for decision-makers to eliminate contradictory committee feedback.

Deploy the RACI Matrix Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed prior to sprint one.

Protocol: Designate a single client sign-off lead with binding approval authority.

Chapter 03: Asset Ingestion & Brand Vault Setup

Never allow missing credentials or brand vectors to block engineering sprints.

Establish a secure single-link credential and asset vault deposit portal.

Gate Rule: Sprint 1 strictly begins only after 100% Tier-1 assets are verified in vault.

Chapter 04: Milestone Definition & Definition of Done

Break major projects into unambiguous 2-week sprint deliverable packages.

Define explicit Definition of Done DoD criteria for every asset.

Exit Gate: Deliverables are locked upon written or digital portal sign-off.

Chapter 05: Async Review Protocols & 72-Hour Sign-Off SLA

Replace time-consuming review meetings with structured async video walkthroughs.

Define a contractual 72-hour review window in the Master Services Agreement.

Action: Standardize feedback into binary approval or modification requests.

Chapter 06: Payment Gates & GST Milestone Releases

Safeguard agency cash flow with strict payment-gated sprint transitions.

Rule 1: 50% upfront retainer collected prior to sprint commencement.

Rule 2: Automated GST tax invoicing generated immediately upon phase sign-off.

Chapter 07: Scope Drift Control & Change Order Matrix

Standardize the protocol for pricing and scheduling out-of-scope client requests.

Response Architecture: Never say No; say "Yes, absolutelyâ here is the estimated sprint adjustment."

Require digital sign-off on change orders before commencing supplemental work.

Chapter 08: Project Handoff & Retainer Conversion

Transform one-off project clients into recurring quarterly advisory retainers.

Deliver a strategic 6-month growth roadmap during the final delivery showcase.

Secure recurring monthly advisory agreements to compound agency lifetime value.

Appendix A: Standard Master Services Agreement Checklist

1. 72-Hour Review SLA Clause
2. IP Transfer Contingent on Final Payment
3. GST & Statutory Tax Compliance Provisions
4. Milestone Sign-off and Dispute Escalation Matrix

Appendix B: Cora Autonomous Workspace Integration

Automate all 8 onboarding phases directly inside the Cora Platform.

Deploy branded review portals, manage milestone vaults, and streamline retainer billing.

Visit <https://heycora.in> to explore autonomous agency infrastructure.